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AT ONE OF New Delhi's latest bars, Barbet & Pals, co-founder and mixologist Jeet Rana is shaking an espresso martini into being. It arrives cool, frothy, faintly bitter, and caffeinated.

A few buildings away, at Sidecar, a bar known as much for its many accolades as for its cocktails, 'Kaapi Time' is a signature. Across town, at its sister bar in Gurugram—The Brook—it is the rum espresso martini with a double shot of espresso, that's frequently ordered.

Coffee, once a morning ritual, has found a new hour.

And thanks to that, coffee liqueur is stepping into the spotlight. It's slow but steady arrival is shaped as much by India's evolving café culture as by a growing appetite for premium, flavour-led drinking.

"Coffee liqueur has started feeling a lot more relevant in India," says Samarth Prasad, Co-founder of Himmaleh Spirits that launched Bandarful coffee liqueur in January 2024. "People today are moving towards more premium, experience-led drinking," adds Ansh Khanna, the brand's other co-founder. The shift they describe is visible not only in what is poured, but in how it is appreciated. Things like where the beans come from, how they are processed, etc., now matter as much as the flavour profile.



SPILLING THE BEANS

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COFFEE CULTURE

Over the past decade, India's relationship with the coffee bean has deepened. Single-origin labels, cold brews, and home-grown cafés have introduced a generation of drinkers to varied flavour profiles and nuance. And coffee liqueur is an extension of that. "It doesn't feel foreign; it feels like an extension of what people already enjoy," says Rana. Adds Vikram Damodaran, Chief Innovation Officer, Diageo India, "There is a natural familiarity with coffee in India, which makes coffee liqueur an easier entry point compared to many other flavours.